at Mahad, and Venu (Bhagirathi after marriage), the third daughter of Balwantrao Mahagaonkar. (There were thirteen children in all, of whom three died in infancy and one girl who died at the age of nine.) Deshmukh started his schooling at the age of four in the Mahad primary school and later studied at the school in Tala. In 1904, the family moved to Roha where a new court had opened. Having completed most of his primary education at Tala, Deshmukh attended the Roha primary school for about a year and then joined middle school in a private institution started by three teachers. It was here that he met his first guru Purushottam Joshi, who taught him English and under whose tutelage he got double promotions.

On completion of middle school in 1907, Deshmukh was sent to Bombay for further studies, since Roha had no high school in those days. He stayed with his maternal uncle in a chawl in Lamington Road and enrolled in the Aryan Education Society's High School in Girgaum. Deshmukh showed an aptitude for Sanskrit and stood first in the exam leading to Class VI. His class teacher was Ramachandra Krishna Lagu who was an MA in Sanskrit and Deshmukh soon became his favourite student. Lagu, who joined Elphinstone College as a lecturer in English in 1913, remained his mentor throughout school and college and it was due to his prompting that Deshmukh appeared for the ICS examination.

After Class VI, Deshmukh was admitted to Elphinstone High School where life was quite pleasant. However, since Deshmukh was young for his class he could not appear for his matriculation examination. In those days no student was allowed to appear for his matriculation until he had completed sixteen years of age. This detention of three years in the same class gave him a chance to greatly improve both his English and Sanskrit and laid the foundation for future academic success of a very high order.

Deshmukh appeared for the matriculation exam in 1912 and topped it winning the first Jagannath Sankarsett Sanskrit Scholarship and two other scholarships. He later learned that he had scored 50 out of 50 in each of the two papers in Sanskrit and since no one had ever scored 100 per cent in Sanskrit, the examiners had mutually agreed to deduct two marks each. Deshmukh regarded his detention as a blessing which he felt determined the future course of his life. According to him, he may not have done as well in the matriculation examination, had he taken it in 1910 or 1911 or for that matter any of the subsequent examinations of the University of Bombay,